



YOUR HIGHSTREET ONLINE

Bringing East Lothian's High Street Online

*Why we're built differently — and what we're asking of East Lothian
Council*

Prepared for

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This has been tried before — here's exactly why it didn't last

"An online marketplace to help local shops compete with the big chains" is not a new idea. Scotland — and the whole of the UK — has already had a good-faith, well-funded attempt at almost exactly this. It's important to be upfront about that, and about precisely what went wrong, because S-Move Dealer has been designed from the ground up to avoid repeating the same mistakes.

ShopAppy (2017–2023)

A "virtual high street" directory for local shops — click-and-collect, delivery, pay-on-pickup. Reached **120+ UK towns**, including Kirkcaldy, the first in Scotland. Council-and-BID backed, award-winning, a genuine 2020 pandemic success story.

Ceased trading October 2023. The founder relaunched it in 2026 as a media/editorial site — abandoning the platform model entirely.

Trouva

A venture-capital-backed marketplace aggregating independent boutiques nationally — the same core idea, scaled with outside investment.

Collapsed into administration, leaving independent retailers owed an estimated **£954,000** with no payout. Growth-at-all-costs, squeezing the shops that made it work.

Why they failed — the two root causes

- 1. Operational complexity outstripped what a small, single-staff shop could sustain.** ShopAppy asked shops to keep real-time inventory, take online payments and manage delivery — every new feature added complexity rather than reducing it.
- 2. The funding model wasn't durable.** ShopAppy relied on council/BID subsidy for shop subscriptions — when the free year ended, retention fell off a cliff. Trouva relied on investor growth pressure, which ended in squeezing the very shops it was meant to help.

Discovery worked well in both cases — the idea of banding local shops together online is sound, and demand for it is real and proven. It's the *economics and the operational burden* that broke. That is the specific problem S-Move Dealer has been designed to solve.

How S-Move Dealer is built differently

The points below start with the foundation, then go straight to the single feature that does the most work: turning the exact flaw that broke the last major UK attempt at this into S-Move Dealer's biggest opportunity (point 2).

1 Always free — for shops, and for the community

WHAT BROKE SHOPAPPY A weekly subscription fee, kept alive only by a council or BID paying the first year. When the subsidy ended, so did most of the shops.

OUR APPROACH Listing and selling on S-Move Dealer is **free, forever** — no listing fee, no commission on a sale, no subscription required to appear or to sell. A shop keeps 100% of every sale. There is nothing here for a council to fund, and nothing that unwinds if a grant ends.

2 The centrepiece — we create the need, then we build the solution

THE INSIGHT

The moment any business lists on S-Move Dealer, it becomes a **multi-channel retailer** — trading in its shop *and* online — whether it planned to or not. That's a genuinely new problem for a small independent: the same physical stock now has to be tracked and kept accurate in two places at once. This exact problem is the specific, fixable flaw we identified in Section 1 as what broke the last major UK attempt at this idea.

So alongside creating that need, S-Move Dealer builds the tool that solves it: **PoS & Stock-Sync** — a shop's own phone becomes the till. Scanning a barcode at the point of sale does three things at once: takes the sale, updates the online listing automatically, and turns that barcode into a customer-facing and advertising touchpoint in its own right, not just a stock-control label. Paired with the AI listing assistant (point 7), a shop gets the complete toolkit: AI to list an item in minutes, and a till that keeps it accurate from then on, automatically, as a byproduct of a normal sale rather than a separate chore. It's also being built to keep working through connectivity gaps — able to take payments and manage stock even if the shop's WiFi drops.

NOT A PROMISE — ALREADY WORKING

This isn't a roadmap slide. The same PoS & Stock-Sync system is **already in active, everyday use today**, tracking and selling S-Move Removals' own resale stock — items recovered through our own removals and house-clearance work, sold through S-Move Dealer's own built-in shop. Real conditions, not a demo.

What's left isn't "build it" — it's two things: growing the shopper customer base on S-Move Dealer that makes the tool worth an independent shop adopting, and a further stretch of development time to take it from "works well for us" to a clean, flawless product ready for many different shops to rely on at once. The core concept is already proven; what remains is scale and polish, not invention.

SECTION 2 (CONTINUED)

3 A free branded website is included, not sold separately

THE BARRIER

Many independent shops in East Lothian have no website at all — building one, even a free one, competes with running the shop day-to-day.

OUR APPROACH

Every shop that joins gets its own branded shop page automatically — logo, colours, its own listings — as part of the free core service, not an upsell. A shop can be discovered online the same day it signs up, with no web-building skill required.

WHY FREE — AND WHY IT'S NOT JUST CHARITY

Giving away a shop's website costs us little to provide, but it isn't pure generosity: every shop that uses it is, in effect, advertising the whole platform for free. A customer one shop brings to its own page is now one click from every other shop and listing on S-Move Dealer too — the reciprocity flows both ways, for every shop at once, not just the one that brought the customer in.

1. **No online presence yet?** A strong, easy entry point — full tools included, nothing to build.
2. **Already online?** It supports the shop's existing presence rather than replacing it — the page links straight out to their own website and to whichever other platforms they already sell on.
3. **Advertises the whole platform.** Every customer one shop brings in is now exposed to every other shop and listing too — traffic one business generates for itself compounds for everyone else.
4. **No shop is left to build visibility alone.** Raising awareness of a single independent shop by itself is hard and expensive — banded together, the effort of every shop lifts every shop.
5. **A real head start for brand-new businesses.** A startup with no marketing budget gets an instant, professional online presence from day one — a genuinely better chance than going it alone.

SECTION 2 (CONTINUED)

4 Directory-first — every shop listed from day one

THE COLD-START PROBLEM

A platform that only shows shops who've actively signed up looks empty at launch, which makes it a hard sell to the very next shop.

OUR APPROACH

Every independent shop in the area is listed in the directory from the start, whether or not they've joined yet — signing up simply lets a shop *claim and personalise* its own page. This is designed to sit **alongside** East Lothian Council's own business directory and Shop Local campaign, as the discovery-and-buy layer they don't currently have — not to compete with or replace them.

SECTION 2 (CONTINUED)

5 How it's actually funded — four streams, in order of reliance

THE FUNDING CLIFF

ShopAppy's income came from the same shops it was trying to help, propped up by short-term council/BID subsidy. When that subsidy ran out, so did most of the shops.

Our approach is built on four separate income streams, layered by how much the business currently relies on each one — none of them a fee charged to a shop just to exist on the platform:

1 Community donations **Smallest reliance**

One-off or monthly gifts from shoppers who want to help keep S-Move Dealer free for everyone. Entirely optional, and never something the platform's survival is built to depend on — a genuine bonus, not a budget line.

2 Business sponsorship **Moderate reliance**

An optional monthly fee from a business that wants extra visibility. As a thank-you, it places the business in a dedicated sponsors' sidebar on the main page for direct exposure and quick access to their shop page — it never improves where that business's own products rank in search or browse results (see point 6). More relied on than donations, but still not the core of the model.

3 Banner & mid-listing advertising **Core income**

Paid advertising placements for local businesses, sold once a real shopper customer base is established — this is intended as the platform's **core, ongoing income stream**. It's still being developed and tested, and is not part of the initial launch either way.

4 PoS & Stock-Sync subscription **Additional, growing**

A paid subscription for shops who want the advanced till/stock tool described in point 2 — already proven in our own use, and a separate, optional revenue stream on top of the always-free core listing service as it's rolled out more widely.

None of the four requires a shop to pay anything just to exist on the platform or to make a sale — that stays free, permanently. This is exactly what avoids the ShopAppy subsidy cliff: nothing here unwinds if a grant ends, because nothing here was ever propped up by one.

SECTION 2 (CONTINUED)

6 Ranking is earned, never bought

WHAT BURNED TROUVA'S SHOPS Trust collapsed when a platform's growth pressure put its own investors ahead of the retailers on it.

OUR APPROACH A shop or product's position in search and browse results is earned purely by genuine shopper views and votes — it can never be bought, by anyone, at any price. The optional sponsorship in point 5 only buys a place in a separate sidebar panel; it never changes where a shop's products actually rank. This is disclosed openly, not buried in terms and conditions.

7 AI does the hard part of listing an item

THE TIME/SKILL BARRIER Asking a busy shop owner to write good product listings, one by one, is exactly the kind of "extra job" that made ShopAppy's tech burden too heavy for a single-staff shop.

OUR APPROACH A shop owner takes a photo of an item; our AI drafts the title, description and a suggested price automatically. If a listing sits for a week with no views, the same AI suggests how to improve it. Paired with the Stock-Sync till in point 2, the whole point is to make joining, listing *and* keeping stock accurate take minutes, not hours.

SECTION 2 (CONTINUED)

8 Local and independent only — never national chains

S-Move Dealer is restricted to **local, independent sellers across Edinburgh & the Lothians** — no national chains, no out-of-area sellers riding in on the traffic local shops generate. Every pound spent through the platform is a pound that had the chance to stay in the local economy, in line with East Lothian's own Community Wealth Building goals.

9 Open to the whole community, not just registered shops

Independent shops, regular sellers and one-off individual sellers are all welcome side by side in one shared catalogue — a household clearing out a garage is as much a part of the local economy as the shop on the corner. This also means the platform never looks empty while shops are still being signed up one by one — the whole community can help stock it from day one.

10 Every local business, eventually — service businesses follow once there's an audience

S-Move Dealer is for every local independent, not only those selling physical items — but **local service businesses (trades, personal services, professionals) are a deliberate next step, not a launch-day feature**. Before launch, a service business has nothing to physically list to help fill the shelves, and the platform has no shopper traffic yet to make joining worthwhile for them — tackled at once, those two gaps just reinforce each other. Bringing on businesses with items and listings first is what builds the real shopper traffic that then makes joining genuinely worth a service business's time. They're catered for by design — simply sequenced to when there's something real to offer them, not left out.

SECTION 3

Where things stand today — and why we're being deliberate

In keeping with the honesty this whole approach is built on: S-Move Dealer is **home-grown in East Lothian** (S-Move Technologies Ltd, registered in Ormiston, EH35 5LE) and is currently in an active, hands-on beta — onboarding shops directly and refining the platform against real feedback before any wider push. We have deliberately not set a fixed public launch date; we are releasing responsibly as each part is genuinely ready, not against a marketing deadline.

115

independent East Lothian shops
already mapped for outreach

680+

independent shops mapped across
Edinburgh & the Lothians

0%

commission or listing fee —
then and always

What this means in practice

- We already know the East Lothian independent-retail landscape in detail, town by town, well ahead of any wider promotion.
- We are talking to real shop owners now, in person, and building the platform around what they actually need — not a spreadsheet exercise.
- The PoS & Stock-Sync tool (point 2) isn't a promise either — it's already running today on our own resale stock; what's ahead is customer growth and polish, not proving the idea.
- Everything built so far has been self-funded from personal savings, deliberately in the lowest-cost way possible — which has also meant it competing for time against Alex's day-to-day work running S-Move Removals.

What we're asking of East Lothian Council

S-Move Dealer doesn't just align with East Lothian's own **Local Economy Strategy 2024–2034** — its "Grow our Economy" and "Prosperous" aims — it's a direct delivery mechanism for it: local job creation, keeping spend on the local high street, and complementing (never duplicating) the Council's existing Invest East Lothian directory and "Love East Lothian / Shop Local" campaign. We're asking for four things:

Ask	What it means in practice
Introductions	Inclusion in Invest East Lothian's business communications, so independent shops hear about S-Move Dealer from a trusted local source.
Co-promotion	Mentioning S-Move Dealer alongside the existing Shop Local / Love East Lothian messaging, as the online discovery-and-buy layer that complements it.
A pilot conversation	An open discussion about whether a specific East Lothian town centre could act as a supported first showcase for the approach.
Funding	See below — a specific, itemised, time-limited amount, precisely costed rather than picked for effect.

Why we're now asking for funding

Everything described in this document so far has been **self-funded from personal savings**, built in the lowest-cost way possible. That approach has a real cost: it limits how much time Alex can actually dedicate to S-Move Dealer alongside running S-Move Removals day-to-day. The ask below is sized to fix exactly that — not to fund a large team or a big media campaign, and explicitly **not** a request to replace Alex's income from the removals business with a full salary.

The figures below come from an itemised expenditure analysis (available in full, with editable assumptions, as a supporting spreadsheet) — nothing here is a round guess.

The funding ask, itemised

What it funds	£ / month	Why
2 part-time support staff 20 hrs/week each, ~£13/hr + employer NI/pension	£2,591	Onboarding help, listing moderation, shopper support — modest part-time roles, not two full-time hires.
Local advertising campaign	£600	A modest paid-social + local-press awareness campaign across Edinburgh & the Lothians — not a national spend.
Alex — personal time-buy-back	£1,200	A modest stipend, not a director's salary — just enough to justify shifting hours from S-Move Removals into S-Move Dealer.
Infra growth headroom	£100	Extra hosting/AI capacity as the seller base grows during the funded push.
Total new monthly ask	£4,491	The current self-funded running cost — hosting, AI, messaging, domains, social media advertising and content production — is £510/mo , and continues to be covered personally either way.

£35,000

target ask — ~7.8 months
of this itemised package

£9,000

potential match funding identified
(S-Move Removals → S-Move Technologies investment, see below)

£35,000 is not a round number picked for effect — it's the exact ceiling of East Lothian's own Business Growth & Innovation Capital Grant, and it equals ~7.8 months of the genuinely itemised package above. On match funding: that scheme's 20% match requirement (worst-case reading: £8,750) is within reach — S-Move Removals could invest up to £9,000 into S-Move Technologies at 0% interest — **but this is not yet committed**. S-Move Removals can only actually make that investment once a firm repayment plan is in place; S-Move Removals' own finances can't absorb a missed repayment on its own credit line, so this is a genuine, identified route to match funding rather than cash already set aside. We recognise a grant of this specific name may also be capital-only and could exclude staff/marketing (revenue) costs — we'd welcome your guidance on match-funding timing and on which actual funding route, if any, fits revenue costs like these.

Is this a normal ask? What East Lothian Council actually funds

Rather than guess, we looked at what East Lothian Council has actually approved recently. £35,000 is neither unusually small nor large against the Council's own record:

Scheme	Typical award	Example
New Business Support Grant	up to £1,000	Newly self-employed / incorporated businesses
East Lothian Investments Young Entrepreneur Award	£1,500	Sam Stevenson, SS Coaching (Tranent), 2024
UKSPF Skills Fund	£1,000–£5,000	Employer skills/training projects
Business Growth & Sustainability Grant	£5,000–£20,000	Per applicant business
Community Intervention Fund (capital)	£4,500–£50,000/project	8 organisations shared £172,782 in 2025
Local event funding	£20,000 each	Fringe by the Sea, Lammermuir Festival, Gosford Winter Wonderland
Business Growth & Innovation Capital Grant	£15,000–£35,000	Our target ask sits at the top of this band

Why strategic fit matters here, beyond the number

This isn't a request to fund something that's merely nice for the community alongside everything else the Council does — S-Move Dealer's stated aims (reviving the local high street, keeping spend local, banding independents together) map directly onto outcomes East Lothian's own strategy is already trying to deliver. Funding it is a way of directly resourcing the Council's own priorities, not a favour to a separate, unrelated venture.

A note on the wider region

S-Move Dealer's footprint already spans all four Edinburgh & Lothians council areas (Section 3), and similar, proportionate conversations are planned with Midlothian, West Lothian and Edinburgh as the platform grows into those areas too. East Lothian is deliberately approached first — it's home turf, and the natural reference site the other three conversations can point to. This ask is East Lothian's own, not a slice of a shared pot.

SECTION 4 (CONTINUED)

Thank you for taking the time to consider this. I'd welcome the chance to talk it through, show the platform directly, or answer anything this document raises.

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